

COLLEGE PREPARATION - Dia Talari

How to choose:

BRIEF DESCRIPTION

- Choosing a college is one of the hardest decisions you'll make in school, not just because of the necessary steps to get there, but knowing how to follow the right path. With thousands of colleges, and endless rankings and majors, it's easy to get mixed up in so much advice, and end up choosing what is best based on others, not you. The truth is, there is no such thing as a perfect college, just what's a perfect fit for you; And that is exactly what college prep will help achieve: A college that fits YOUR goals, interests, learning style, and budget. This guide will help you focus on what actually matters so you can make the decision that you spent 12 years working towards.

PERSONAL EXPERIENCE

- When I first started researching colleges, I had no idea where to begin. I assumed the process was simply about finding the most prestigious school I could possibly get into. As I started exploring more and more colleges, I quickly realized that choosing a college is much more personal and requires thought and intake of different priorities - Whether it's a specific major, affordability, campus culture, people, location, research opportunities, or career outcomes. Once I shifted from believing others to believing myself and my goals, I had the chance to grow more academically and personally. One advice I would give to every student starting this journey is to choose the place where you can envision yourself growing and learning and thriving; Becoming the person you want to be is far more important than what others believe you to be.

MAIN POINTS

- Before researching colleges, spend time learning about yourself. Ask questions such as:
 - What subjects do I enjoy the most?
 - Do I have a career or major in mind?
 - Would I want to stay close to home or go international?
 - What kind of campus culture would help me succeed?
 - What is my budget range and do I have any scholarships?

- Academics are a major factor, but have you thought about factors such as:
 - Student Organizations
 - Campus traditions
 - Housing options
 - Diversity and Inclusion
 - Campus safety
 - Recreation and clubs

- If you have the opportunity, visit campuses or attend virtual tours. Statistics are great, but reality is more part of your own story. Walk through campuses, speak with current students, and attend information sessions displayed by them to figure out which college is the right fit.
- Instead of asking “Can I get accepted here?” think about personal growth and the ability to achieve higher things after college. Think about your job and future achievements. Think about personal growth and beyond. These are the dreams that will be achieved when you choose what’s right for you.

RESOURCES

- College Board
- U.S. Department of Education
- NCES
- Official college admissions websites

SUMMARY

- Choose a college that is fit for you not only based on academics, but based on future visions and dreams. Take time to understand your goals, research your options, compare colleges thoughtfully, and consider academic and personal factors before making your decision. A college should help you grow, and thrive, not eliminate your possibilities.

